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***Working paper introducing the analytical framework for
comparing approaches and strategies of the selected
external actors***

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1. Introduction¹

There is little doubt that the twentieth century was one of the bloodiest in human history globally and on the European continent (e.g. Ferguson 2006: 4-9). At the same, the end of the 20th and the start of the 21st century has brought remarkable change in particular for Western Europe. Many people have taken this transformation as an expression of the possibility that nations are able to leave historical experiences of conflict behind and, instead, focus on mutually beneficial cooperation and shared values. With the end of the Cold War and the breakdown of the Soviet Union, the same transformative logic built on Western values has spread eastward. However, today we know better that the eastward spread of liberal and Open Access Orders (OAOs) did not follow a linear development and, rather many post-Soviet countries are stuck in transition processes.

While the overall research program of EU-STRAT applies an inside-out logic to unlock the puzzle of an incomplete transition, this paper operates with a more traditional outside-in perspective to provide insight into how a variety of external actors approach Eastern Partnership (EaP) countries. This perspective refers to the observation that EaP countries are often seen as a space where the influences of diverse external actors intersect to support or constrain domestic processes. The characteristic pattern of the intersecting influences in the “shared neighbourhood between the EU and Russia” (Ehin and Avery 2007) is one of conflict rather than of cooperation. Although European Union (EU) enlargement in 2004 created important spill-overs with regard to the impact of EU policies on these neighboring countries, several years later the importance of other external actors, in particular of Russia, has increased. This has become particularly visible since 2008, with Russia employing military instruments and initiating economic integration processes that transformed the external context of the political and economic processes in Ukraine, Moldova, Georgia and other Eastern neighbors and their relationship with the EU. The EU and Russia may be the most prominent but they are by no means the only external actors in the region affecting calculations of the domestic elite in EaP countries. There are other state actors such as China, Turkey and the United States (U.S.) as well as international organisations, such as the International Monetary Fund (IMF), that have principled or selective policies geared towards countries in Eastern Europe.

The main purpose of this paper is to develop an analytical framework that allows for a comparison of approaches and strategies that selected actors employ across different sectors in the EaP countries since the EaP’s launch in 2009. The paper is based on the assumption that external actors can and do affect socio-political orders in the EaP countries in multiple ways, by formal and informal means and, most importantly, in very different directions. Despite a growing literature that addresses, for instance, push and pull factors towards democracy promotion or autocracy supporting external policies, our substantial knowledge about the forms and dynamics of cross-pressuring of post-Soviet countries in general, and on the states that are part of the both the EU’s European Neighborhood Policy (ENP) and Russia’s “near abroad”, is relatively limited, with differences in the degree to which different policies are being acknowledged.

The present paper prepares the ground for further research in EU-STRAT’s Work Package 4, which in a comparative approach seeks to achieve a number of broader objectives. First and foremost, we aim to improve our knowledge about the characteristic strategies of external actors towards EaP countries in general and in a selected number of important policy areas in particular. Secondly, we seek to identify

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areas of complementarity and competition between the strategies and policies of different external actors. Last but not least, building on these insights, we hope to lay the foundation for informing European policy-makers on how to better aid EaP countries in developing towards OAOs as well as in how to adjust EU engagement with the other external actors present in the region.

The task of this paper is limited to the presentation of the analytical framework for comparing approaches and strategies of external actors vis-à-vis EaP countries. In developing the building blocs of the framework, we will refer to insights of studies on particular actors, for instance, the EU and a select number of its member states. Such references may illustrate specific aspects of the foreign policy approaches of individual countries and, moreover, may indicate that there is generally no shortage of studies on this topic. It would also be incorrect to state that there is no literature on relations between external actors in general or with respect to their interactions in the region under study. On the contrary, literature on the relationship between the EU and Russia is booming and provides a variety of foci and insights (see e.g. Kagan 2009 on the increasing competition between great powers; Delcour and Wolczuk 2017 on the difference between the EU and Russia as regional powers). For the present study, we address a broader variety of external actors active in the EaP countries such as Russia, the U.S., Turkey, China and international organisations. This framework will additionally serve to guide a comparative analysis of these actors' strategies and approaches in a number of different policy areas.

In order to derive a coherent framework with distinguished categories for comparison, the paper will continue with a review of literature that revolves around the theme of strategy and strategic action. Informed by this review, the paper presents an inter-related list of criteria that constitutes our take and will guide the comparative approach. The paper concludes with a discussion of our methodology.

2. Strategy in foreign policy: a review

With our interest in the differences in external actors' strategies, we enter into the realm of a number of larger debates on the concept and features of strategy. To start with, Burnell indicates three important dimensions. Firstly, he points out that strategies of states cannot be divorced from their larger foreign policy framework (Burnell 2005: 361). Secondly, he reminds us that choices for external policies are more often than not the result of intense domestic negotiations (ibid.: 363). Thirdly, his analysis indicates that strategies can range from complex to simple (ibid.: 364). Let's address these issues in turn.

The first of Burnell's points refers to a discussion of an actor's foreign policy framework. This seems to be the most familiar aspect, as every state has foreign policy and we are used to discussing the respective foreign policy of China, Russia or the U.S. The situation, however, is a bit trickier with regard to the EU. While for quite some time arguments about the specific *sui generis* character of the EU as a political entity, building on the shared distribution of powers between the member states and the European institutions, stood against the acceptance of the EU as a foreign policy actor, the winds have changed over the past years. Today, it is largely acknowledged that the EU *has* a foreign policy that can be compared to the foreign policies of other states or entities (e.g. Hill 1996; Risse-Kappen 1996) and the literature is quite supportive in disembarking the EU out of its *sui generis* quarantine. Keukeleire and Delreux define EU foreign policy, as "the area of European policies that is directed at the external environment with the objective of influencing that environment and the behaviour of other actors within it, in order to pursue interests, values and goals" (2014:1). Although it is multifaceted, multimethod and multilevel, it can still be considered as the foreign policy of an international actor. Put differently, the EU spells out its commonly agreed political, economic and, so far to a much lesser extent, military aims. It states its foreign policy strategy in documents; translates its objectives into policies; and it has an institutional set-up to implement external policies (Bretherton and Vogler 2006: 24 et sqq.). A more recent example of the analysis of EU foreign policy, based on the assumption that the EU can be analysed

in the same way as other external actors, is the analysis of the responses of external actors to the events in the Arab world in late 2010 and 2011 (Börzel et al. 2015a, 2015b).

With respect to Burnell's second point, it is insufficient to attest that an actor chose a foreign policy merely because it had the ability to agree on said policy, as well as the resources and the instruments at its disposal to implement it (Hill 1993: 315). Rather, the specific manner in which these agreements on policy choices and instruments were made should also be studied. The perspective on domestic politics leads us to open the black box of the state. Foreign policy choices are by no means the result of monolithic actors' decisions, but rather the "explicit aggregation of diverse domestic preferences within political institutions, and the collective systemic out-come is a function of the explicit strategic interaction among these groups internationally" (Milner 1988: 779). As a consequence, a sober comparison may identify interesting differences or similarities in the domestic interest aggregation amongst external actors. For instance, it has been argued that the EU and the U.S. are now similar because they represent two different species of the same political genus: the compound democracy constituted by the union of states and their citizen (Fabbrini 2008). And with a view on policy choices, Burnell states that the EU's strategies for democracy support, which emerged from "strikingly inchoate decision-making processes" with accidental arbitrariness dominating over sophistication (Youngs 2004: 13), may not have been "vastly different" from the "situation in the complex bureaucracy of the U.S. federal government" (Burnell 2005: 363).

A third important line along which external actors' approaches may differ refers to the comprehensive plan guiding their foreign policy, or, put differently, actors may well differ with respect to their strategies. As a basic framework, a strategy would imply at the most general level a substantiated definition of overall objectives that trickles down to provide the guidelines to the delineation of sectoral policies and instruments. While the layman would expect an overarching systematic thinking that guides a state's external action in practice, reality frequently tells a different story. The aforementioned references to the characteristic features of foreign policy decision-making should however not suggest any expectation of greater coherence or complementarity between a foreign policy's overall intended direction vs. how this translates to sectoral policies and instruments in practice. These references may however also indicate that it is worthwhile to compare how states address the challenge of developing coherence in their complex and simple strategic principles, decisions and instruments.

The latter point indicates the importance of the bigger picture. The different ways in which states translate an overarching plan into more or less coherent policies and instruments is at the centre of debate on goals and instruments. The debate comprises not only an assessment of instruments in relation to goals but also both the self-perception of a state in international politics and the image that others have of the respective state. For instance, there are numerous labels assigned to the EU in international politics, including its classification as a military, civilian, economic, normative, soft *or* cultural power – sometimes accompanied by separate questions of "what the EU is" from "what the EU does" to "what the EU should do" (see e.g. Diez and Pace 2007; Manners 2006; Scheipers and Sicurelli 2007; Sijrsen 2006; Peters 2016: 14 et sqq.; Tocci 2008).

The explicit ambition of grasping the big picture is at the heart of the comparative analysis of regional powers. Studies on regional powers provide for some interesting insights on how to accommodate not only the (self-)attributions and actions of political entities, but also on how to integrate their different power attributes into an analytical framework. In general, these studies accept that regional powers are neither monolithic entities nor display the same behaviour across different issue areas. Accordingly, based on different conceptual distinctions, scholars in the realm of regionalism, geopolitics and geoeconomics have developed a number of different typologies of foreign policy strategies and variations of interactions with their respective neighbours.

The way in which these approaches develop ideal-typologies derived from predefined discriminating factors is stimulating for the present interest in comparing strategies of external actors in the EaP area. For instance, with her geopolitical perspective on powers in regions of the world, Prys distinguishes between regional detached powers, regional hegemonies, and regional dominators. Her discriminating criteria are the self-perception, the regional perception, the exercise of power, and the type of goods produced (Prys 2010).

A second example is Wigell's geoeconomic perception of regional powers' strategies which, according to him, may be neo-mercantilist, liberal institutional, neo-imperial or hegemonic. The distinguishing dimensions are the strategic frame (competitive or cooperative) and the economic power (differentiated between goals and instruments) (Wigell 2016).

Finally, Destradi conceptualises different ideal-types of regional actors' strategies in terms of empire, hegemony (hard, intermediate, soft) and leadership that she develops on the basis of a parsimonious distinction between the goals (self-interested/common), resources (material or ideational) and the instruments (threats/sanctions/mutual benefits or normative) of a regional power (Destradi 2010).

There is a noteworthy convergence not only between strands of different literatures but also between academic scholars and political decision makers. On the one hand, Destradi's framework for the comparison of different foreign policy strategies links up to discussions on "what power the EU is" in its self-perception and in relation to other regional powers – here to Russia. What is more, her categorisation allows not only for incorporating a broader range of political, geopolitical, geoeconomic, and normative objectives and instruments but also for a variety of possible combinations of these.

On the other hand, it is this differentiation of different categories of power and their respective combination that speaks to the concept of smart power as has been introduced by Josef Nye (1990, 2004) and translated into the American foreign policy by the then U.S. Secretary of State, Hilary Rodham Clinton. Accordingly, an understanding of statecraft in the 21st century that not only integrates the military dimension and use of geoeconomic instruments, but also softer means, such as development, diplomacy, public-private partnerships and communication tools, to promote and defend national interest. According to her, a modern foreign policy is characterised by the smart choice of the "right combination of tools – diplomatic, economic, military, political, legal, and cultural – for each situation" (Clinton 2014: 33). This approach has become tangible in the form of the 'Quadrennial Diplomacy and Development Review' that seeks to accommodate the short-, medium-, and long-term interests of the U.S. with respective diplomatic and development efforts since 2009. In this respect, Clinton's approach was not primarily aimed at doing geo-economics better (Blackwill and Harris 2016: 25). Rather, it was a general approach to improve the U.S. government's institutional ability to integrate political, economic, and development objectives, as well as instruments and capabilities, into a more coherent foreign policy strategy.

A final aspect that follows from this broader understanding of the constituent features of a foreign policy refers to the necessity of arriving at a better understanding of both who the sender of a foreign policy is and who the recipient in the target country is. On the one hand, the traditional paradigm of foreign policy and international relations builds on government-to-government interaction. This has provided not only for executive control over foreign policies on the side of the external actor, but also on the side of the target country. The implications for the former have made their way into the literature, for instance, in expressions such as the "privilege of the executive" as one of the reasons for international cooperation (e.g. Wolf 1999). However, Tolstrup (2014) turned the focus onto the host countries by granting attention to the way in which specifically positioned elites in host countries ("gatekeeper elites") manage external influences by building, cutting or refusing linkages.

On the other hand, a broadened understanding of foreign “smart” policy needs to take into account a differentiation on both ends of the interaction. In this regard, the concept of public diplomacy indicates that simplified models of government-to-government and diplomat-to-diplomat interactions need to be complemented by government-to-people dynamics (see e.g. Wang 2006). Image cultivation, propaganda and other activities that aim at achieving acceptance of foreign policies abroad address not only other state actors in the host countries but also require different approaches and instruments of the external actor. Furthermore, the carriers of foreign policy objectives may differ. In this respect, the call for a move from “public diplomacy to corporate diplomacy” that has come alongside the acknowledgement of an increasing political role in particular of multinational companies (Ordeix-Rigo and Duarte 2009) is mirrored by the observation that transnational business actors may carry the fundamental principles of one society to another in their cross-border trade relations. An example would be the group of small and medium enterprises in Turkey (“the “Anatolian Tigers”) that have diffused a quite conservative interpretation of Islam through their activities in the Balkan countries, thus complementing other soft power instruments of Turkish foreign policy (see e.g. Hosgör 2011).

To conclude, the admittedly eclectic review of important contributions of different literature has helped to identify a number of dimensions that can aid in the design of an analytical framework that allows for structured comparison of foreign actors’ strategies and approaches towards the EaP countries. In what follows, we suggest conceptualising these dimensions in term of a cascade from the most general to the most concrete dimensions.

3. Analytical framework: a cascade of dimensions

Building on the insights of the literature above, we will develop an analytical framework that serves two guiding purposes. On the one hand, it is important to capture as much empirical information as possible when studying the strategies and approaches of external actors in the EaP countries. On the other hand, this comparison has to follow a stringent structure. However, in designing a framework for a focused comparison, we will not build on a single framework – we are at least unaware of any off-the-shelf candidate for such at present. This implies also that we refrain from forcing our insights into the Procrustean bed of a set up with dependent and independent variables. Rather with the objective of achieving the utmost degree of clarity and stringency, we adopt a more pragmatic approach that recruits and elaborates on the dimensions derived from the review above. We order this dimension in the form of a cascading set of analytical categories that begins with the most general elements of a foreign policy and trickles down to a more concrete class of observations. Accordingly, the following dimensions are to serve for a structured, empirical comparison of the strategies of different external actors towards the EaP countries:

1. **Guiding principles** refer to the *fundamentals and overarching features* of a foreign policy, with “grand strategy” being the key concept.
2. **Goals** are long-term aims that define the *purpose* of an external actor’s foreign policy with respect to EaP countries; goals have a general purpose towards the target country (or region) and are distinguished from sector specific objectives.
3. **Objectives** are concrete attainments defined in terms of *policies and instruments* applied vis-à-vis EaP countries generally and in particular sectors; including types and amount of resources allocated for particular efforts and activities.
4. **Carriers of external policies and target groups** refers to the types of actors that constitute the actual interaction process between the external actor and the EaP country in the pursuit of a particular policy.

3.1 Analysis of guiding principles

The concept of grand strategy figures at the most general level. International relations scholars (and practitioners) have interpreted the concept in essentially three different ways: with respect to its roots in the language surrounding and related to the challenges of war, with regards to the hierarchy of concepts (military, political, economic) that inform how the state acts in strategic terms, and finally, in a much broader political and non-military sense (Martel 2014: 26). A substantial interpretation defines a grand strategy as “a coherent statement of the state’s highest political ends to be pursued globally over the long term” (ibid.: 32). This implies not only a “conceptual framework [of] how the world is,” but one that “envisions how it ought to be” (Krasner 2010). This may also specify the set of instruments and policies meant for achieving political goals, military force as well as diplomatic, economic and technological efforts, plus the coordination of all goals, interests, and assets of an actor (Gray 1999: 54).

Vital interests of actors that are relevant for grand strategies include physical security, economic prosperity and value projection (Deibel 1992; Smith 2011). Although grand strategies are quite persistent and do not change substantially over time, the combinations of vital interests, goals and assets employed may change over time. It should be noted that the interests and goals of an actor are not a given. They are formulated in a specific environment involving the historic experiences, specific values and narratives possessed by the actor. These experiences, values and narratives might explain why e.g. China in general is more inclined to pursue economic interests in its international activities, or why the EU’s behaviour is very often driven by the promotion of rules. In our framework of analysis, we define these specific experiences, values and narratives as guiding principles that define the approaches and strategies of the actors. These guiding principles help to rationalise the strategic behaviour of an actor. Secondly, they also provide historic perspective on the strategic behaviour. Thirdly, they help identify potential challenges to the international activities of an actor, as those goals, interests and patterns of behaviour that fall within the general line of the strategic rationalisation are easier to implement. Finally, identification of the guiding principles could be instrumental in forecasting the future patterns of a particular actor’s strategic behaviour. Actors in the international system act on the basis of their grand strategies, which provide them with general direction and guidelines, thereby formulating a framework of preferable choices for any given circumstance.

Grand strategy is a very broad category that requires an operationalisation in the form of division into separate components. Smith suggests dividing the EU’s grand strategy into three components: grand strategy oriented toward the EU itself (intra-EU), toward the EU’s immediate region (neighbourhood) and toward the global system (Smith 2011). For our purposes, we reorder the latter two and identify the following set of dimensions and questions for the analysis of external actors’ strategies.

Firstly, we address the internal dimension and address the self-conception of an actor. The self-conception of an actor is a subjective understanding an actor holds of itself. In order to understand the images of the self, role theory can be used (Thies 2009, Harnisch et al. 2011). Roles are defined as “the notions of actors about who they are, what they would like to be with regard to others, and how they therefore should interact in (international) social relationships” (Harnisch et al. 2012: 1-2).

Secondly, we focus on the vision the actor holds of the international system. We compare how external actors understand the nature of the international system and how they understand their foreign/external policy goals. The general perspective is important as it allows outlining the premises under which their strategies are drafted and various instruments are applied. For our research within the framework of this category, we will try to answer the following questions: 1) how the actor defines its role in the international system (what kind of power it is, i.e. military/civilian, unilateral/multilateral player, active/passive etc.); 2) what views an actor has vis-à-vis the polarity of the international system; 3) whether relationships in the international system are perceived to be a cooperative, competitive or

conflictual; 4) how an actor defines the nature of its main threats and prioritises them; 5) what are the main allies and rivalries; 6) does the actor want to change the system or to preserve the status quo (revisionist/satisfied).

Thirdly, we address how an actor approaches the region in general terms. Though we realise that various external players might have different approaches vis-a-vis the region, some might be more interested in particular countries rather than the region as a whole, or might have a broader conceptualisation of the region. Our analytical framework refers to the general definition of the EaP region when defining sets of variables that characterise the actors' approaches vis-a-vis region (or particular countries). We have to answer the general question of how an actor approaches the region (the role of the EaP region in the actor's strategies and policies). What is the level of general importance of the EaP region or specific countries for a particular actor? We also need to ask how the goals of foreign policy towards the EaP states in particular fit into the overall goals of an external actor's foreign policy (their "guiding principles"). Thus we present the framework for comparative analysis of the external actors' strategies vis-à-vis EaP countries, which we will first address by defining its main elements and the logic behind them.

3.2 Analysis of goals and objectives

Moving one step down on the level of abstraction, we address the dimension of goals, defined as the long-term *purpose* of an external actor's foreign policy, with respect to EaP countries. As has been mentioned, these goals can have a general purpose towards the targeted country or they may be more sector specific. Goals make overarching strategising more concrete by defining more specifically the ends of a strategy. They also indicate a specific understanding of the way in which ends and means (e.g. instruments or allocation of resources) will be related. In this regard, goals and related processes of translation into means are the defining elements of any strategy (for a discussion of political strategies see Fisher et al. 2007).

There are different types of arguments used by actors to conceptualise their foreign policy goals. The existing literature on the external actors' goals in targeted states agrees on the fact that both democracy promotion, as well as its alternative, autocracy promotion, is very rarely a clearly defined and isolated foreign policy goal. Much more often regime change or stability is a side effect of or subordinate to other intentions and objectives. External actors usually have competing interests and goals, and their simultaneous pursuance of these may have distorting consequences. For instance, in their analysis of the role of external actors during the Arab Spring events, Börzel et al. (2015) identify three general groups of goals pursued by external actors: (a) promotion of rules of the game, (b) guaranteeing security and stability, (c) pursuance of economic interests (access to resources or promotion of trade interests). When applied to non-democratic players, Tansey (2015) provides a more detailed classification of the reasons driving external actors' behaviour. He argues that by interfering in the domestic affairs of target states they may: (a) be reacting to a shifting international balance of power; (b) seek regional stability to prevent a spill-over of political turmoil; (c) be trying to secure domestic stability and survival of the dominant coalition; (d) be defending their economic interests in the target state. Hubner (2015) classifies goals of external actors according to the same logic and makes a distinction between *security*, *identity*, and *utilitarian* goals.

On the basis of the analysis of strategic documents, policy statements and other sources, it is possible to make a comparison of external actors in terms of what they are trying to achieve by making external interventions. If we accept the assumption that goals vary by their substantiation, it is important to know what the logic is behind external actors' activities and what level of importance they attach to their goals. In other words, *homogeneity or multiplicity of the goals* pursued by external actors is an important factor

to look at. Furthermore, we move beyond the Smithonian distinction between the intra, the global and the regional dimension of strategies by adding a sectoral facet to the board.

Building on this understanding is the following operationalisation of the dimensions for comparing the goals of external actors:

1. Security/stability goals: variations of these goals include (a) focusing on an international balance of power; (b) seeking regional stability; (c) securing domestic stability (preventing spill-over), but the presence of any of these considerations in external actors' discourse would count as evidence of security-related goals.
2. Utilitarian goals: facilitating trade, investment and other types of exchange, either generally or in particular sectors.
3. Identity (value) goals: (a) promotion of human rights, rule of law, and other principles of liberal democracy; (b) promotion of principles that characterise autocracies or non-articulation of goals linked to values and general principles of social order.
4. The role that support for change (or preservation of the status quo) plays in the strategy of external actors. The question is whether domestic change/preservation of the status quo is the goal in itself, or more an instrument to achieve other (broader, overt/covert) goals vis-à-vis the target countries.

We will also differentiate general goals defined in the strategies from more concrete objectives that are set in particular policy areas. Accordingly, we ask:

5. Is the engagement of an external actor comprehensive and focused on a wide variety of issues, or selective and restricted to a limited area of select policy objectives?

On the sectoral level, we will discuss what objectives are set within an external actor's strategy for the trade, migration, energy, or security sector of EaP countries. What external actors aim to achieve in the energy, trade, migration, or security sector is mainly an empirical issue for each EaP country. Because of that, it is important to collect country-specific data on what each external actor has been trying to achieve in a specific EaP country. The analysis should start by comparing the relevance of an EaP country's specific sector to an external actor. This is needed in order to understand the level of importance of mutual relations in specific sectors and how this is reflected in policy documents. Importance (to the respective external actor) will be measured by:

6. Trade: the percentage of trade with the EaP country in total volume for external actors; Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) from an external actor in the EaP country as a percentage of its total foreign investments; presence/absence of concentration of trade in one/several specific sectors (indicative of special vested interests among the players within external actors).
7. Migration: patterns of migration between an external actor and EaP country, visa regimes and other rules governing movement of people.
8. Energy: pattern of dependence (is the external actor a supplier or recipient; interconnectedness by pipelines; presence of transitory status of an EaP country from an external actor's perspective).
9. Security: threat perception of an external actor in reference to the EaP country; unresolved international (border, financial, proprietary) issues; participation in common security organisations; interdependence of the military-industrial complex, and arms trade.²

² We will refer to the database of Work Package 3 for relevant information on a range of these issues.

Finally, it is important to have in mind that “the goals external actors pursue may not only conflict with each other; they can also clash with the goals of other external actors seeking to secure their influence in the region” (Börzel et al. 2015a: 7). Therefore, there is also a need to determine the interplay of goals of external actors and to address the responsiveness of actors to other actors’ goals (and actions).

10. Do external actors respond—in terms of seeking to reinforce vs. to counter—to the goals and objectives of other external actors? This question must clearly be addressed within our analytical cascade on that of two levels: for goals and for objectives.

3.3 Analysis of objectives: policies, instruments and resources

Different mechanisms and varieties of instruments can be used by external actors while trying to achieve their goals in the EaP countries. Following Börzel (2015), we suggest differentiating between three general groups of instruments employed by external actors:

1. Conditionality tries to manipulate cost-benefit calculations through creating positive and negative incentives. This mechanism has also been referred to in the democratisation literature as leverage. The perspective of a closer association (and related benefits) with the external actor may help to buy off domestic veto players that block the domestic reforms the external actor demands for the costs they incur.
2. Enforcement does not leave domestic actors any choice, either based on utility maximisation or on considerations of appropriate behaviour. Actors are legally obliged or physically coerced to comply with external actors’ policies and expectations. Legal coercion has to, however, be distinguished from the use of military force in the sense that member states or accession candidates have voluntarily agreed to be subject to legal coercion by virtue of them being international organisation members or candidates for membership. For example, Russia can legally punish Belarus as a member of the Eurasia Union.
3. Assistance enables choices rather than imposing or inducing them, building the capacity of domestic actors to make and implement them by providing them with financial resources and technical expertise.

These categories may contain a variety of specific instruments applied by external actors, ranging from military intervention to political dialogue and trade privileges, or from subsidies to civil servants trainings. Rather than *a priori* formulating assumptions about how specific external actors operate, it remains an empirical task to analyse which instruments are specific to which actors.

As Ademmer’s (2017) research has shown, it is also important to see if external actors apply external instruments generally, or specifically. Ademmer has made a conclusion that general external sanctions/incentives (i.e. not specified to which sector or decision they apply) tend to have a less clear impact, and that the highest level of effectiveness has been achieved in cases of clearly specified and targeted applications of external conditionality. Therefore, it seems important to offer one further criteria for comparison of external actors: how *specific* vs. *general* are external actors’ proposed incentives and conditionality in dealing with the EaP countries.

Analyses of the resources that external actors devote towards the achievement of their goals in the EaP region can be indicative of their capacities and comparative weight. A distinction can be made between the type and amount of resources. Resources can be material, for example, financial resources – which encompass funds allocated to the implementation of policies towards EaP countries – as well as loans or credits provided by external actors. They can also take the form of institutional resources, such as the number of embassies/consulates/honourable consulates/trade promotion agencies and related staff an

external actor has in EaP countries. However, it is mainly an empirical task to collect data on what kind of resources are accumulated and employed by different external actors.

3.4 Carriers and targets of external actors' policies

Wetzel (2015) suggests analysing external influence by comparing what elements of domestic situations or which audiences are mainly targeted by external actors in the EaP countries. Such an approach looks promising from the Limited Access Order (LAO) theoretical point of view because it allows for an identification of the targets of external actors within EaP countries and creates the possibility of comparing the impact of external influences on specific elements of LAOs.

For the purpose of the comparative framework, we suggest applying the definitions of the substance of democracy by Merkel (2004) and Wetzel (2015) in order to form a target map, which shows the differences in the target audiences of various external actors. In addition to noting the level and sites of interaction, we may want to pay attention to the type of actor, if more than just state actors are involved and, if so, to the way in which these non- or semi-state actors are incorporated into the formulation and implementation of the external actor's strategy.

We will outline which external actors establish relations with which types of domestic actors in the EaP countries, particularly paying attention *inter alia* to the dominant elites (who control power, resources, and rents), competing political and economic actors and civic society groups, and to formal as well as informal networks (as even the definition of state vs. non-state actors may differ depending on the particular context and social order i.e. Orthodox Church in Russia).

Table 1 summarises the basic elements of the comparative framework. The detailed comparative analysis of these elements in the case of each selected external actor with regard to specific sectors will be performed in the next stage of empirical analysis.

Table 1: Framework for assessing approaches and strategies of external actors towards EaP countries

Dimension	Categorisation	Sector specific			
		Trade	Migration	Energy	Security
Guiding principles	Military/Civilian power				
	Unilateral/Multilateral power				
	Pro-active/Passive power				
	Cooperative/Competitive power				
	Allies/rivalries				
	Bipolar/Unipolar/Multipolar system				
	Zero-sum/Positive sum system				
	Main threats				
Goals (general) objectives (sectoral)	Revisionist/status quo attitude towards system				
	Security, utilitarian, identity				
	- policies				
	- instruments				
Carriers & targets of external actors' foreign policy	- resources				
	State actors, quasi state actors, non state actors				
	dominant elites, opposition groups				

Source: compiled by authors

4. Methodology and case selection

The methodology for the first research portion (comparing strategies and approaches, identifying goals and objectives) will be based on document analysis of strategic documents (e.g. national security strategies, foreign policy strategies/concepts, EU Global Strategy, country assistance programmes by the IMF, etc.), as well as of speeches and interviews by heads of states/organisations and foreign policy institutions or other relevant policy-makers. Additionally, we will examine joint resolutions and policy documents of the respective countries or institutions defining their policies and actions either towards the EaP region or the target countries. The methods for document analysis will encompass content and discourse analysis. Interviews with relevant policy-makers from the selected external actors (countries or organisations) will be conducted if necessary. The analysis of instruments and resources will be based on relevant policy documents in each specific issue area, descriptive statistical data and its analysis, and the analysis of specific policy decisions and their implementation.

We distinguish four types of external actors: the EU as a whole, EU member states (Germany, France, Poland and Lithuania), other international and regional powers (Russia, bilaterally or through the Eurasian Union, U.S., China, and Turkey), and international institutions (IMF, World Bank, the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO), the Organization for Security and Co-operation in Europe (OSCE) and the Council of Europe). We consider these to be the most significant external players in the region, having both a high level of engagement and impact. The external actors also differ in their engagement principles. There are a) those who support the maintenance of LAOs (China and Russia); b) those who support transformation into OAOs (EU, selected EU member states, U.S., international organisations); c) those who have an ambivalent approach (Turkey). Our findings will reveal to what extent external actors countervail or complement the EU's strategies in the EaP region. We will not analyse all policies and instruments of all actors in all issue areas, but have rather chosen those areas deemed most important to the selected external player, and those which entail enough policy activities towards the particular EaP country to assess.

5. Conclusion

To sum up, in order to undertake a comparative analysis of external actors' strategies and approaches with respect to EaP countries, we suggest the use of a composite framework comprising four dimensions in a cascading logic: 1) guiding principles as the broadest category of an external actors' foreign policy, including the self-perception of its role international affairs; 2) goals, as holding the long-term perspective and defining the purpose of a foreign policy towards a target country or region. Goals are sometimes synonymous with the 'ends' of a foreign policy. Their general level distinguishes them from 3) specific objectives, which are concrete attainments defined in terms of policies and instruments applied vis-à-vis EaP countries generally and in a particular sector; finally, 4) we address who the agents of the foreign policy (carriers) are and who the target in the EaP country (target group) is. This distinction pays tribute to the growing complexity of international and transnational relations. We propose the ways and indicators that should allow for an operationalisation of these dimensions and provide an analytical basis for systematic comparison. This will in turn be used in later work to assess the effects of external actors on EaP countries and the interplay between different external actors.

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